

Please Rob Me!

Location sharing is rising as a trend in the social media space. It is very common to find your twitter feed populated by inane updates by your contacts telling you where they are. There are websites dedicated to register these check-ins like Foursquare which is a web and mobile application that allows registered users to connect with friends and update their location, thus earning them points.

This may seem innocuous on the outset, but a new website is trying to inform people about the dangers that can be associated with location sharing. With a name like PleaseRobMe.com, this website is a funny way of looking at location sharing. PleaseRobMe is website which aggregates a stream of updates from various location based networks which shows users who have checked in to some place other than their home. The idea is that if the user is in that location, his house is lying free to be robbed.

The website states its objective as follows: The goal of this website is to raise some awareness on this issue and have people think about how they use services like Foursquare, Brightkite, Google Buzz etc. Because all this site is, is a dressed up Twitter search page. Everybody can get this information.

Although there is a remote possibility of robbers in India being as tech savvy, but there have been cases in the US where burglary attempts have been made after referring to location sharing sites.

Google Maps now comes with Labs

Google has come out with the Labs feature for Google Maps, which is represented by the

green vial in the top right menu. With the help of Labs you can try out nine new features (which are disabled by default). These features have to be enabled for them to work.

Lets have a look at some of the interesting features:

Drag n Zoom: This eases zooming into the map. You have to draw an area on the map and click Drag n Zoom and

Where in the world game: A very engaging game which will help you brush up your geography skills. It basically shows a zoomed in portion of a map alongwith four options from which you have to select the correct one.

Aerial Imagery: Aerial imagery gives you rotatable, high-resolution overhead imagery presented in a new perspective. As of now there are only certain areas on the map which have this option enabled.

Rotatable Maps: This lets you rotate the maps such that the southern hemisphere is placed on upper part of the map and vice versa.

Smart Zoom: It prevents you from zooming in only upto the portion where imagery is available, preventing you from getting the message "We dont have imagery at this zoom level"

There are other features also like Latitude and Longitude marker among others. All the features may not work in all areas of Google Maps, as this



Good old BBS

is relatively new feature. But with the Labs addition to Google Maps, you can look forward to some engaging developments on Maps

A walk down memory lane as BBS turns thirty two

Before the internet came along with its luxuries of colourful pages, video chat, e-mail and streaming videos, the only communication available between computer users was using an electronic BBS (Bulletin Board). All you needed was a modem and even in India, BBS's were buzzing.

College students were the ones behind it here. There were a couple of popular ones in major cities and there were a group of regulars who visited them. The news of BBS's only spread by word of mouth and through magazines.

To connect to one, you would have to keep redialing for a very long period of time — all thanks to busy and sometimes noisy disturbance ridden phone lines. After all, BBS's were setup by enthusiasts at home and typically, only five to ten users could be connected at a time. Once connected, you would have access to a few

documents, a couple of downloadable shareware games, couple of text-based RPGs, a chat program and of course, a message board — all of which were refreshed from time to time. At a time when getting any kind of data (documents, games, applications, etc) was only possible through floppies exchanged by hand, this was an exciting discovery! There was no multitasking either — so if you wanted to chat with someone, you would have to just wait on that screen till someone came around. It was the arrival of dialup ISPs and some free ISPs that spelt the end of the BBS era sometime towards the late 90s.

More than three decades after BBS's first came around, the internet has taken over everything, and those who experienced BBS's would agree that we've been pampered in the last few years. The value of the data visible is only truly appreciated by a few. Those who want to check out what the craze was about, and for those who want to revisit the nostalgia, visit www.synchro.net/sbbslist.html. BBS's have moved to the internet and you can connect to them. At least now, you won't connect via a 14.4kbps modem and a rickety telephone line, instead a Telnet client and an internet connection will do just fine. **[d]**

